

Session 9: A Flood of Violence

Key Takeaways

- The kings of Genesis 14:1-10 are portrayed as personifications of evil and corruption through their names and other symbolism.
- The kings eliminated the groups of giants, recalling the Nephillim whose violence ruined the land and brought on the flood.
- Avram's dramatic rescue of Lot is depicted as miraculous, validating Avram's status as God's chosen agent.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 14:1-16

a ¹ And it came about in the days of **Amraphel**, **king** of **Shinar**,
b of **Aryok**, **king** of **Elasar**,
c of **Kedorlaomer**, **king** of **Elam**,
d and of **Tidal**, **king** of Goyyim (= "nations"),
a ² that **they made war** with **Bera** (= "in evil"), **king** of **Sodom**,
a' and with **Birsha** (= "in wickedness"), **king** of **Gomorrah**,
b and with **Shinab** (= "father hater"), **king** of **Admah**,
b' and with **Shemeved** (= "name of destruction"), **king** of **Tsiboyim**,
c and with **the king** of **Bela** (= "devour") [this is Zoar].
³ **All of these joined together** in the **valley of Siddim** [this is the Sea of Salt]

a ⁴ For **twelve years** they had been slaves of **Kedorlaomer**,
a' and in the **thirteenth year** they rebelled,
b ⁵ and in the **fourteenth year** **Kedorlaomer** **went**,
b' and the kings who were with him,
a and **they struck** the **Rephaim** in Ashteroth-Qarnayim (= "Asherah of Twin-Peaks")
a' and the **Zuzim** in Ham,
a" and the **Emim** in Shaveh-Qiryathayim (= "the Plain of Twin-Cities"),
b ⁶ and the **Horites** in the mountains of Seir,
b' unto the Oak of Paran which is by the wilderness.
c ⁷ And they returned and **they went** to Eyn-Mishpat (= "the Spring of Judgment") [this is Qadesh]
and **they struck** all the field of the **Amalekites**,
c'

c' and also the **Amorites** who dwell in Hatzetzon-Tamar (= "Heap of Palms")

- a 8 And **the king of Sodom** went out,
b and **the king of Gomorrah** ,
b and **the king of Admah** ,
b and **the king of Tsiboyim** ,
b and the king **of Bela** [this is Zoar]
a' and they **lined themselves up for war** in the **valley of Siddim** ,
a 9 against **Kedorlaomer, king of Elam** ,
b and **Tidal, king of Goyyim**
b and **Amraphel, king of Shinar** ,
b and **Aryok, king of Elasar** .
c Four kings against five.
a 10 Now, the **valley of Siddim** was full of **many pits** of tar.
b And **they fled**,
c **the king of Sodom, and Gomorrah** ,
b' and **they fell** into there.
a And those **remaining** fled to the **mountains** .

- 11 **And they took**
all the **possessions** of **Sodom and Gomorrah** ,
and all their **food** ,
and **they went away**.
12 And **they took**
Lot and his **possessions** ,
the son of the **brother** of Avram,
and **they went away**.
Now, he was dwelling in **Sodom** .

- a 13 And a **refugee** came and **reported to Avram the Hebrew** .
b **Now, he was dwelling among the oaks of Mamre** the Amorite,
b the **brother** of Eshkol, and the **brother** of Aner.
b Now, they **were members of a covenant** with Avram.
a' 14 And **Avram heard that his brother** had been taken **captive** .

- a And he brought out **his trained men**,
b **those born of his house**,
b' three hundred and eighteen,
a' **and he chased them** unto Dan.

- a 15 And **he divided himself against them** by night,
 b **he and his servants**
 a' and **he struck them**,
 a'' **and he chased them** unto Khobah, which is north of Damascus,
 a 16 and he returned all the **possessions**,
 a' and also **Lot** his **brother** and his **possessions** he returned,
 b and also the women and the people.

Genesis 14:1-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Of Kings and Giants

The story highlights these repeated lists of kings. The lists are arranged in symmetrical patterns, and the names of the kings are loaded with sarcastic wordplays.

Mesopotamian Kings: 1st List	Mesopotamian Kings: 2nd List
A Amraphel, king of Shinar B Aryok, king of Elasar C Kedorlaomer, king of Elam D Tidal, king of Goyyim	C Kedorlaomer, king of Elam D Tidal, king of Goyyim A Amraphel, king of Shinar B Aryok, king of Elasar
Canaanite Kings: 1st List	Canaanite Kings: 2nd List
A Bera, king of Sodom B Birsha, king of Gomorrah C Shinab, king of Admah D Shemeved, king of Tsiboyim E The king of Bela [this is Zoar]	A The king of Sodom, B The king of Gomorrah C The king of Admah D The king of Tsiboyim E The king of Bela [this is Zoar]

Mesopotamian and Canaanite Kings Lists. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The list of nine kings is repeated two times, but not identically. The order of the four Mesopotamian kings is inverted so that the king of Shinar is number one in the first list, and the king of Elam is number one in the second list.

This seemingly random variation becomes meaningful when the story is mapped out in its literary sequence.

A - Amraphel, king of Shinar
B - Aryok, king of Elasar

C - Kedorlaomer, king of Elam
D - Tidal, king of Goyim

A - Bera king of Sodom
B - Birsha, king of Gomorrah
C - Shinav, king of Admah
D - Shemeved, king of Tsevoyim
E - the king of Bela [this is Zoar]

Kedorlaomer and the Kings With Him Strike the Giant Clans

- Rephaim / Zuzim / Emim
- Horites / Amalekites / Amorites

A - the king of Sodom
B - the king of Gomorrah
C - the king of Admah
D - the king of Tsevoyim
E - the king of Bela [this is Zoar]

C - Kedorlaomer, king of Elam
D - Tidal, king of Goyim

A - Amraphel, king of Shinar
B - Aryok, king of Elasar

Genesis 14:1-10 Kings. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The names have been listed in symmetrical pattern, which places the Mesopotamian kings at the outer locations and highlights the giant clans in the center position. Each of these design features seems intentional and communicates something significant.

The inverted Mesopotamian kings: The two kings highlighted are the rulers of Shinar and Elam. Both kingdoms play a significant role in the larger biblical story.

Shinar

Shinar was last mentioned in [Genesis 11:1-2](#), in the genealogy of Ham, son of Noah: "And all the land ... journeyed east and found a plain in the land of Shinar and they settled there" and began building Babylon.

Shinar is a rare term used to describe the flood plain in which Babylon and its ziggurats were built. Every time it appears in the Hebrew Bible, it is ominous:

- "The beginning of Nimrod's kingdom was Babylon ... in the land of Shinar" ([Gen. 10:10](#))
- "On that day, Yahweh will a second time with his arm restore the remnant of his people from Assyria, Egypt ... Elam, Shinar ... and from the islands of the sea." ([Isaiah 11:11](#))
- "[Nebuchadnezzar] brought the vessels of the temple of *Elohim* to the land of Shinar, into the treasury of his *elohim*." ([Daniel 1:2](#))

Elam

"Elam" is the Hebrew word for "Persia," and was last mentioned in the genealogy of Shem, son of Noah: "The sons of Shem: Elam, Ashur, Arphaxad, Lud, and Aram" ([Gen. 10:22](#)).

Interestingly, Elam/Persia is the nation that topples Babylon and becomes the instrument of God to restore the exiled Israelites back to the promised land (see [Ezra 1:1-11](#)).

Later, the king of Babylon (descendant of Ham) will exile Avram's descendants to the land of Shinar, and Elam (son of Shem) is the nation that will restore those exiles back to their homeland.

The list of Canaanite kings is repeated identically, and most of the names come from the genealogy of Ham in Genesis 10.

Genesis 10:6, 19 NASB

⁶ The sons of Ham were Cush and Mizraim and Put and Canaan. ... ¹⁹ The territory of the Canaanite extended from Sidon as you go toward Gerar, as far as Gaza; as you go toward **Sodom** and **Gomorrah** and **Admah** and **Zeboiim**, as far as Lasha.

This precise linking of the kings to the list of Noah's sons in Genesis 10 is intentional. The author is trying to show that this battle is an outworking of the sibling rivalry that Noah anticipated in Genesis 9:25-26.

Genesis 9:24-26 NIV

²⁴ When Noah awoke from his wine and found out what his youngest son had done to him, ²⁵ he said, "Cursed be Canaan!

The lowest of **slaves** will he be to his brothers."

²⁶ He also said, "Praise be to the LORD, the God of Shem! May Canaan be the **slave** of Shem."

Genesis 14:4-5 Instructor's Translation

⁴ For twelve years [the sons of Ham] had been **slaves** of Kedorlaomer, and in the thirteenth year they rebelled, ⁵ and in the fourteenth year Kedorlaomer came, and the kings who were with him [sons of Shem]

The Mesopotamian Kings Versus the Giants

The eastern kings come to Canaan and strike the giant clans associated with the Nephilim, the giant warriors from the time of the flood.

Rephaim in Ashteroth Qarnaim

The Rephaim were a clan of giants, with a king named Og who ruled in Ashteroth, in the region of Bashan on the east side of the Jordan River.

Deuteronomy 3:8-11 ESV

⁸ So we took the land at that time out of the hand of the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan, from the Valley of the Arnon to Mount Hermon ... ¹⁰ all the cities of the tableland and all Gilead and all Bashan ... cities of the kingdom of Og in Bashan. ¹¹ (For only Og the king of Bashan was left of the remnant of the Rephaim. Behold, his bed was a bed of iron. Is it not in Rabbah of the Ammonites? Nine cubits was its length, and four cubits its breadth, according to the common cubit.)

Joshua 13:12 ESV

all the kingdom of Og in Bashan, who reigned in Ashtaroth and in Edrei (he alone was left of the remnant of the Rephaim); these Moses had struck and driven out.

The Greek Septuagint translators of Genesis rendered the Rephaim of [Genesis 14:5](#) with the Greek word *gigantas* (γίγαντας) = “giants,” the same word they use to translate “Nephilim” in [Genesis 6:4](#).

The Zuzim (זוזים) in Ham

The Zuzim, also known as the “Zamzummim” (זמזומים), lived in the region later inhabited by the Ammonites, who were actually part of the Rephaim giant clans.

Deuteronomy 2:19-21 ESV

¹⁹ ... I will not give you any of the land of the people of Ammon as a possession ... ²⁰ It is also counted as a land of Rephaim. Rephaim formerly lived there—but the Ammonites call them Zamzummim— ²¹ a people great and many, and **tall as the Anakim**; but the LORD destroyed them before the Ammonites, and they dispossessed them and settled in their place

The Emim in Shaveh-Qiryataim

The Emim were also actually part of the Rephaim giant clans.

Deuteronomy 2:10-11 ESV

¹⁰ The Emim formerly lived there, a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim. ¹¹ **Like the Anakim** they are also counted as Rephaim, but the Moabites call them Emim.

All of these tribes are connected to the Anakim and the Nephilim from the time of the flood.

Numbers 13:27-33 ESV

²⁷ And they told him, "We came to the land to which you sent us. It flows with milk and honey, and this is its fruit. ²⁸ However, the people who dwell in the land are strong, and the cities are fortified and very large. And besides, we saw the descendants of Anak there. ²⁹ The Amalekites dwell in the land of the Negeb. The Hittites, the Jebusites, and the Amorites dwell in the hill country. And the Canaanites dwell by the sea, and along the Jordan." ... ³² "The land, through which we have gone to spy it out, is a land that devours its inhabitants, and all the people that we saw in it are of great height. ³³ And there we saw the Nephilim (the sons of Anak, who come from the Nephilim), and we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers, and so we seemed to them."

This entire list of the inhabitants of Canaan and the Transjordan provides an accounting for all the regions that the Israelites will later enter in Numbers 20 onward. These regions were filled with earlier inhabitants, clans of giants who were dealt with by God's providential justice long before Israel entered into the land.

Deuteronomy 2:9-11, 18-23 ESV

⁹ And the LORD said to me, "Do not harass Moab or contend with them in battle, for I will not give you any of their land for a possession, because I have given Ar to the people of Lot for a possession." ¹⁰(The **Emim** formerly lived there, **a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim**. ¹¹Like the **Anakim** they are also counted as **Rephaim**, but the Moabites call them **Emim**. ¹²The **Horites** also lived in **Seir** formerly, but the people of Esau dispossessed them and destroyed them from before them and settled in their place, as Israel did to the land of their possession, which the LORD gave to them.)

¹⁸"Today you are to cross the border of Moab at Ar. ¹⁹And when you approach the territory of the people of Ammon, do not harass them or contend with them, for I will not give you any of the land of the people of Ammon as a possession, because I have given it to the sons of Lot for a possession." ²⁰(It is also counted as a land of **Rephaim**. **Rephaim** formerly lived there—but the Ammonites call them **Zamzummim**— ²¹**a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim**; but the LORD destroyed them before the Ammonites, and they dispossessed them and settled in their place, ²²as he did for the people of Esau, who live in Seir, when he destroyed the Horites before them and they dispossessed them and settled in their place even to this day. ²³As for the Avvim, who lived in villages as far as Gaza, the Caphtorim, who came from Caphtor, destroyed them and settled in their place.)

Moses' speech in Deuteronomy 2 assumes a backstory of God's judgment on the giant clans on the east side of the Jordan, and Genesis 14 supplies that narrative. The point of Moses' speech is that just as God providentially gave other lands to the non-chosen descendants and relatives of Avraham (Lot or Esau), so also he will use the Israelites to dispossess the Canaanites. Genesis 14 provides the providential backstory, implying that God used the eastern kings led by Babylon as a divine instrument of judgment on the giant clans of Canaan and Transjordan. However, because of Babylon's over-assertion in the capturing of Lot, the seed of Avraham, God then delivers the coalition over to Avraham.

This chapter, then, makes Avram the superior to the eastern kings, the Canaanites, and all the giants of the ancient time. It also qualifies Avram to be the true inheritor of these very lands, because he was their deliverer.

This all seems aligned with a strategy that sets the returnees from exile on analogy with Avraham. They too (re)entered “Canaan” (= Persian *Yehud*) after God had used Babylon to judge the previous inhabitants (the Israelites and Judean kingdoms along with the non-Israelite population), and found themselves called to inherit it according to God’s promise.

A Flood of Violence

Recall that Genesis 11-14 retraces the thematic sequence of Genesis 1-9, and Genesis 14 comes at the precisely the moment we are expecting a flood/re-creation moment. The story is filled with unique connections to the onset of the flood narrative.

Genesis 6-8	Genesis 14:1-24
The mighty violent warriors (Heb. <i>gibborim</i>), also called “Nephilim, men of the name” (notice the prominence of names in this chapter) spill much blood on the land, filling it with violence. Gen. 6:4 The Nephilim were on the earth in those days, and also afterward, when the sons of God came in to the daughters of men, and they bore children to them. Those were the mighty men who were of old, men of the name. Gen. 6:13 Then God said to Noah, “The end of all flesh has come before me; for the earth is filled with violence because of them; and behold, I am about to cause their ruin them with the land. The flood-waters are called “mighty and strong” (Heb. <i>gavar</i>, גבר), from the same root as “mighty warrior” (Heb. <i>gibbor</i>, גבור). Gen. 7:18-20 ¹⁸ The water was mighty (Heb. <i>gavar</i>, גבר) and increased greatly upon the land ...	• The Mesopotamian kings strike the Rephaim and other giant clans (Gen. 14:5, LXX γιγαντας), connected to the Anakim (Deut. 2:10-11, 3:11-13) and the Nephilim (Num. 13:33). • The Mesopotamian kings become a flood of divine judgment that consists of warriors (<i>gibborim</i>) sweeping through the land promised to Avram, clearing out its previous inhabitants.
<i>Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Genesis 6-8

Genesis 14:1-24

¹⁹The water was **mighty** (Heb. *gavar*, גבר), very very much upon the land, and all the high hills under the skies were covered.
²⁰The water was **mighty** (Heb. *gavar*, גבר) fifteen cubits higher, and the mountains were covered.

Gen. 7:11 The flood happens as the “fountains of the deep abyss” split open, and the “windows” (Heb. *‘arubbot*, ארבת) open up.

Gen. 11:3 The tower and city of Babylon, which were scattered in a flood-like judgment, were built by “tar” (חמר) used as mortar.

After the flood, Noah and his family are a remnant (נשאר/שאר), and they escape and are placed upon the “mountains of Ararat.”

Gen. 7:23 “Only Noah, together with those with him in the ark, was left remaining (נשאר).”

Gen. 8:4 “In the seventh month ... the ark rested upon the mountains (הר) of Ararat”

Gen. 8:21 After the flood, God refers to the waters as a “strike” upon the land (נכה) — “I will never again **strike** (נכה) the land as I have done.

God makes a covenant promise to Noah, that he will provide a refuge for him and his family in the ark built of trees (עץ), where he can live in safety with the animals and plenty of food.

Gen. 6:14 “Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees (עץ) ...

Gen. 6:18-19 “But I will set up my covenant (ברית) with you and so you will enter the ark, you and

The kings of Sodom and Gomorrah fall into pits of pitch.

Gen. 14:10 Now, the valley of Siddim has pits, pits (בארות בארת) of tar (חמר).

After the flood-like attack of the kings, the survivors flee to the mountains.

Gen. 14:10 ... and those left remaining fled to the mountains (הר).

The Mesopotamian kings come and “strike” (נכה) the giant clans.

Gen. 14:5, 7 Khedorlaomer came ... and **struck** (נכה) the Rephaim ... and they **struck** (נכה) the field of the Amalekites.

Gen. 14:13 While the battle rages around Avram, he sits in peace among the oak trees of Mamre.

Gen. 14:13 While corrupt Canaanites are being struck all around, a group of Canaanites who are in a covenant (ברית) with Avram, sitting with him, are perfectly safe

Gen. 14:11-12 The Mesopotamian kings come and

Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 6-8	Genesis 14:1-24
your sons and your wives and your sons wives and every living thing of all flesh ... in order to keep them alive with you.” Gen. 6:21 “And take (לקח) for yourself food (מאכל) that you will eat (אכל) and gather it for yourself.”	“take” (לקח) both the “food” (אכל) and Lot from Sodom.
Gen. 5:21, 28-29 Noah is the great-grandson of Enoch (חנוך) Gen. 5:29 Noah (נח) ... “this one will comfort us (ינחמנו) us” Gen. 6:8 But Noah (נח) found favor (חן) in the eyes of Yahweh	Gen. 14:14 Avram prepares his “dedicated men” (חנכי).
<i>Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

These hyperlinks establish Avram, the seed of Noah, as a new Noah who is delivered from the Mesopotamian kings’ flood of violence and who becomes the agent of God’s deliverance and judgment.

Avram is the agent of God’s deliverance because the Canaanites who are in a covenant with him are delivered and safe from the Mesopotamian attack.

Avram is the agent of God’s judgment because he and the Canaanites with him strike back against the Mesopotamian kings, overcoming them and rescuing the captives of Sodom.

In this story, the cursed Canaanites are struck by wicked kings of the east, who are depicted as a flood of wickedness. While God’s providence is not explicitly evoked, it does appear to be a judgment on the Canaanites, who, by extension from Sodom and Gomorrah’s “great evil and sin” ([Gen. 13:13](#)), deserve divine justice. But, in contrast to the flood, the violent kings of the east come led by Babylon. This prepares us for the portrait of Babylon as God’s “servant” in [Jeremiah 25](#), who will be used for a time (paralleling [Gen. 14:1-10](#)) until he oversteps his bounds (paralleling [Gen. 14:11-24](#)) and becomes the object of God’s judgment instead of its instrument.

Avram the Hebrew and His Covenant With the Canaanites

The Canaanites are portrayed in two ways.

1. The Canaanites unconnected to Avram are swept away in the battle of the kings who come, strike, and return. Their “wicked” status is indicated by the names of the kings: “In Evil,” “In Wickedness,” “Father

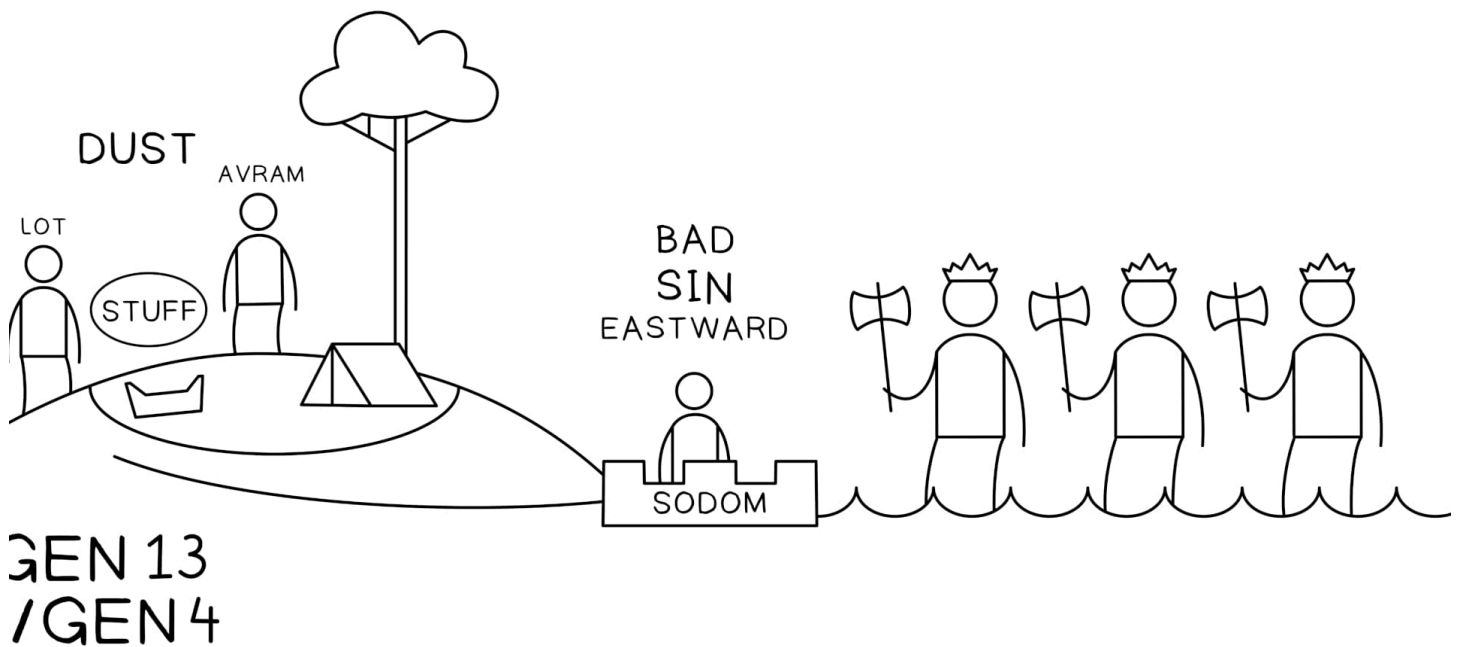
Hater," "Name of Destruction," and "Devoured." These are the Canaanites associated with Avram and Lot.

2. The good Canaanites (Mamre, Aner, Eshkol) hanging out with Avram in his mini-Eden are associated with Avram by covenant. Not only are they spared, but they go with Avram and defeat the violent nations themselves, chasing them all the way "unto Dan" (עד דן), which sounds like the Hebrew for "unto Eden." Note that Eshkol (אשכול) means "Grape Cluster," which is a garden image.

Avram the Commando King-Slayer

This portrait of Avram as the guerrilla warrior is unique in the Avram stories because he is usually peaceable and non-violent in his relationships with the Canaanites. His fighting force of 318 is an odd detail, explained by its relation to Eliezer in the next story.

A Flood of Warrior Kings



Flood of Warrior Kings. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How do the violent kings of Genesis 14 replay the flood theme? How does this help us understand the importance of this episode in Avram's story?